

Living Hell

The second wound. The shame. The flashback.
Life for a rape victim can never be the same.

THE SECOND WOUND

Most often, hiding the crime becomes more important for the family than supporting the victim. The parents of an 18-year-old girl, who was raped by her cousin a year ago in Ghaziabad, decided to act as if it did not happen. When she was raped again, they just asked him to move to a different flat. The matter was not reported on the pretext of family honour. Psychologist Rajat Mitra narrates an incident where a victim was slapped by her mother for revealing the rapist's name during a counselling session. Psychiatrist Jitendra Nagpal, who specialises in child abuse cases and deals with 10 new cases every month on an average, calls it the second wound.

THE FREEZE

In most cases, the victim freezes out of shock. This is also referred to as 'passive resistance', the absence of 'fight or flight' against the perpetrator. Many rapists construe this as consent. Nagpal calls it 'consent by coercion'.

THE FLASHBACK

Most victims experience what is termed a 'flashback' where they relive the agony of being raped, almost with the same intensity. In one unreported case, a college girl, who was raped in a moving car by a friend when she had gone to attend a rave party in south Delhi last year, had a flashback on sighting a

similar car. She is undergoing psychiatric treatment.

SELF-BLAME

Most victims suffer from shame and self-blame. They feel responsible to some extent for what happened to them. Mumbai-based social psychiatrist Harish Shetty says: "Thousands of women silently suffer this plight within their family."

BODY IMAGE DISORDER

'Body image disturbances' are commonly found in rape victims. They feel their bodies are impure. Some get a creepy feeling of worms crawling beneath their skins. The 'dehumanisation' is a difficult feeling to handle for most of them.

ing about it". How can men learn to respect women with such a mindset of stereotypes? A recent study done by The International Centre for Research on Women suggests that 80 per cent of men from Punjab think violence is justified if their wives are "disrespectful" and 60 per cent if their wives "do not follow instructions". Mitra speaks of a middle-aged politician who explained to him in a counselling session that he just couldn't take a no from a woman. Once when he approached a woman at a party and bluntly asked her to have sex with him, he was not put off by her refusal. Instead three days later, with the help of his bodyguard, he broke into her house and raped her. "She did not resist one bit, nor reported the matter to the police, just left the city for



LAL SAI RAPE Bhopal

2006

ACCUSED Lal Sai, a flamboyant godman of Bairagarh, a colony in the city's outskirts

DETAILS On October 18, 2008, a teenaged engineering girl student alleged that the Sai had, sometime in 2006, offered her prasad laced with an intoxicant and raped her while she was unconscious.

CURRENT STATUS Sai surrendered on June 22 and has been remanded to judicial custody till July 7. The CID, which was handed over the investigations, is ready to file the chargesheet.

good," he boasts.

Is the onus to be on women to remain alert and informed? Former police officer and criminology expert, Kiran Bedi, controversially argues yes. "In crimes like these where the perpetrator feels the compulsive need to act, it is the women, who are biologically vulnerable, who will have to avert such happenings. In 80 per cent of the cases, rape can be avoided, such as at rave parties where drugs and alcohol are doing the rounds. It is like walking into a trap." In an environment which fosters poor reporting of rapes, even shoddier justice and a deep rooted bias against women, is it any wonder that the mind of a rapist is often just a snapshot of everything that is collectively wrong?

with Uday Mahurkar, Swati Mathur and Stephen David